KEY TOPIC 3: NAZI CONTROL AND DICTATORSHIP

Paper 3: Weimar and Nazi Germany, 1918-39



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: *From Democracy to Dictatorship: How did Hitler destroy the Weimar Republic?*

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L1: Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise chronological knowledge of the rapid steps Hitler took to secure power between January 1933 and August 1934.
- [ ] Analyse how Hitler used the Reichstag Fire and the Enabling Act to legally destroy political opposition and civil liberties.
- [ ] Evaluate the significance of the Night of the Long Knives and the Army Oath in eliminating internal threats and securing absolute power as Führer.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What was the original name of the Nazi Party?

2. What was the 25-Point Programme (1920)?

3. Who were the SA (Sturmabteilung)?

4. What was the Munich Putsch (1923)?

5. What was the result of the Munich Putsch for Hitler?

6. What was the Kellogg-Briand Pact?

7. When did Germany join the League of Nations?

8. What new currency ended hyperinflation?

9. What was the Dawes Plan?

10. Who led the Spartacist Uprising?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: *Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?*

The Reichstag Fire | The Enabling Act (1933) | Gleichschaltung | Trade Unions | The Night of the Long Knives (1934) | Führer

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:



When Hitler became Chancellor in January 1933, his power was extremely limited. Germany was still a democracy, he did not have a majority in the Reichstag, and President Hindenburg could sack him at any time. Hitler immediately called an election for March 1933, hoping to secure a clear majority.

Six days before the election, on **27 February 1933**, the Reichstag building was burned to the ground. A young Dutch communist, **Marinus van der Lubbe**, was caught at the scene with matches and firelighters. Hitler claimed this was the signal for a violent communist takeover of Germany.

> **Lived Experience: Dolf Sternberger (Eyewitness to the aftermath of the Reichstag Fire, Berlin, February 1933)**
> "The sky over the Tiergarten was blood red. The great glass dome had collapsed. The morning after, the decree was published; overnight, all our constitutional rights, our privacy, our free speech, had vanished."

Hitler manipulated this crisis perfectly. He convinced President Hindenburg to declare a state of emergency and sign the **Decree for the Protection of the People and the State**. This decree legally suspended civil rights—freedom of speech, freedom of the press, and the right to assemble were instantly gone. Using this terrifying new power, Hermann Göring's police arrested 4,000 communist leaders and shut down all opposition newspapers, severely weakening Nazi opponents right before the election.

Despite the violence and intimidation, the Nazis still only won 288 seats (44%) in the March 1933 election —not the two-thirds majority needed to change the constitution.

To gain absolute power legally, Hitler proposed the **Enabling Act**. This law would give him the right to pass laws without the Reichstag for four years. To get the required two-thirds vote, Hitler used his emergency powers to ban the 81 Communist politicians from entering the building.

Hitler still needed more votes, so he struck a deal with the Catholic Centre Party, falsely promising to protect the Catholic Church if they voted for him. Meanwhile, the SA surrounded the Kroll Opera House (where the parliament was temporarily meeting), chanting, 'Give us the bill or else fire and murder!' The remaining politicians were terrified. The Enabling Act passed by a massive margin of 444 votes to 94. **Democracy in Germany was officially dead.** The Reichstag had essentially voted itself out of existence.

Armed with the Enabling Act, Hitler began the rapid process of ***Gleichschaltung***—bringing all of German society into line. He systematically destroyed all external opposition:

May 1933 (Trade Unions): *Trade unions were banned, their leaders arrested, and their funds confiscated. Workers were forced into the Nazi-run German Labour Front (DAF). This meant workers could no longer strike against the government.*

July 1933 (Political Parties): Hitler passed the *Law Against the Formation of Parties*. All political parties except the NSDAP were officially banned. Germany was now a one-party state.

January 1934 (Local Government): *The 18 regional state governments (*Länder*) were stripped of their power, and highly loyal Nazi governors were appointed to run every region directly from Berlin.

By 1934, Hitler's only remaining threat was internal: **Ernst Röhm and the SA**.

The SA had grown to over 3 million men and was intensely loyal to Röhm rather than Hitler. Röhm wanted a 'second revolution' to make Germany more socialist, and he wanted to merge his SA with the regular German army (*Reichswehr*).

The regular army generals and wealthy industrialists despised Röhm. They warned Hitler that if the SA was not stopped, the army would step in and remove Hitler from power. Hitler knew he needed the army to survive. To justify action, Heinrich Himmler and Reinhard Heydrich fabricated evidence that Röhm was planning a treasonous uprising (the 'Röhm Putsch').

On **30 June 1934**, Hitler launched the **Night of the Long Knives**. The SS arrested Röhm and hundreds of SA leaders, dragging them from their beds. Röhm was later shot in his cell.

Hitler used this violent purge not just to crush the SA, but to murder old enemies and settle scores. **Gregor Strasser**, a prominent left-wing Nazi rival, was assassinated. Former Chancellor **Kurt von Schleicher** (who had tried to split the Nazis in 1932) was shot dead alongside his wife. **Gustav von Kahr**

(who had betrayed Hitler during the 1923 Munich Putsch) was hacked to death in a swamp. Vice-Chancellor Franz von Papen was put under house arrest, permanently terrifying him into silence. Approximately 400 people were murdered. Days later, Hitler passed a law making the murders legal, proving that he was now above the law itself.

On **2 August 1934**, President Hindenburg died at the age of 86. Within hours, Hitler declared himself **Führer** (Supreme Leader), officially combining the roles of Chancellor and President.

On the exact same day, the entire German army swore a new **Oath of Allegiance**. Crucially, they did not swear to protect Germany or the constitution; they swore unconditional obedience to the person of *Adolf Hitler*. To cement this, Hitler held a public plebiscite (referendum) in mid-August; 90% of German voters agreed with his new powers. With the army firmly on his side, and the SA broken, Hitler's totalitarian dictatorship was complete.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Which event was more crucial in creating the dictatorship: the Reichstag Fire or the Enabling Act?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson narrative:
1. In January 1933, Hitler became Chancellor BUT...
2. The Enabling Act was passed in March 1933 BECAUSE...
3. The Night of the Long Knives occurred in June 1934 SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Use the following five keywords in a short paragraph (3-5 sentences) that accurately describes a key step in Hitler's consolidation of power, demonstrating your understanding of their meaning and historical context: *Reichstag Fire, Emergency Decree, Enabling Act, Gleichschaltung, One-party state*.

Causal Linkage

Q4. Explain the causal chain linking the growing power of the SA under Ernst Röhm, the concerns of the German Army, and the event known as the Night of the Long Knives. Your answer should clearly articulate how each factor contributed to the next.

Counter-Factual History

Q5. Imagine that President Paul von Hindenburg had lived for another five years beyond August 1934. How might this have altered the pace and nature of Hitler's consolidation of power and the establishment of a totalitarian dictatorship? Consider at least two specific ways Hindenburg's continued presence could have impacted events.

L2: Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise knowledge of the different, overlapping branches of the Nazi police state, distinguishing between the roles of the SS, SD, and Gestapo.
- [ ] Analyse how the Nazis completely removed the independence of the German legal system to ensure the courts always ruled in Hitler's favour.
- [ ] Evaluate the varying successes and failures of Nazi policies towards the Catholic and Protestant churches.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What was the Wall Street Crash (1929)?

2. How did the Wall Street Crash affect Germany?

3. How many Germans were unemployed by 1932?

4. How did the Weimar government react to the Depression?

5. Why did Nazi support surge during the Depression?

6. What was the 25-Point Programme?

7. Who were the SA?

8. What book did Hitler write in prison?

9. What was the Munich Putsch?

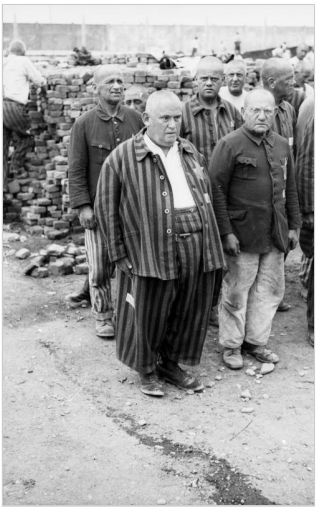
10. Why did the 'Golden Age' end?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: *Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):*

SS (Schutzstaffel) | SD (Sicherheitsdienst) | Gestapo | Schutzhaft (Protective Custody) | The Concordat (1933) | Reich Church | Confessional Church

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:



1. The Machinery of Terror: SS, SD, and Gestapo To maintain absolute control, Hitler could not rely on the regular German police forces, which were run by local governments. Instead, he built a terrifying, highly organised 'Police State' directly loyal to the Nazi Party, operating completely outside normal laws. * **The SS:** Led by Heinrich Himmler, the SS grew from a small bodyguard unit into a massive organisation of deeply loyal, racially "pure" Aryans. By 1936, Himmler was placed in charge of all police forces in Germany. The ruthless 'Death's Head Units' of the SS were responsible for running the concentration

camps. * **The SD:** Formed in 1931 by Himmler and run by his ruthless deputy, Reinhard Heydrich, the SD was the intelligence-gathering wing of the party. They kept a massive card index of anyone suspected of opposing the Nazis, spying on everyone from high-ranking politicians to ordinary citizens. * **The Gestapo:** Also commanded by Heydrich, the Gestapo was the non-uniformed Secret State Police. They had the power to tap telephones, open mail, and use **Schutzhaft (Protective Custody)** to arrest people and send them straight to concentration camps without a trial.

> **Lived Experience: Victor Klemperer (Dresden professor and diarist, recording daily life under the Gestapo)**
> "One never knows who is an informer. The grocer, the postman, the neighbour on the landing... fear sits at the dinner table with every family."

Advanced Analysis: The RSHA and the 'Myth' of the Gestapo By 1939, Himmler consolidated all these overlapping branches (Gestapo, SD, and criminal police) into a single monstrous umbrella organisation: the **RSHA (Reich Main Security Office)**, overseen by Heydrich. Yet, Nazi propaganda deliberately created the terrifying myth that the Gestapo itself was an enormous, all-seeing organisation with agents on every street corner. In reality, the Gestapo was surprisingly small; in 1939, a major city like Frankfurt only had 28 Gestapo agents for a population of nearly half a million. The true horror of the police state was that it relied on **ordinary citizens**. Roughly 80% of all Gestapo arrests were triggered by voluntary denunciations—neighbours, local block wardens ('Blockleiters'), and even children reporting on each other out of spite, jealousy, or brainwashed loyalty.

2. Controlling the Legal System Hitler knew that his police state would only work if the courts supported it. He systematically destroyed the independence of the German legal system: * **The Judges:** All judges were forced to join the **National Socialist League for the Maintenance of the Law**. If a judge did not rule the way the Nazi Party wanted, they were instantly sacked. * **The People's Court:** In 1934, Hitler set up the People's Court ('Volksgerichtshof') to try cases of treason. Juries were abolished. Instead, cases were heard by fanatical Nazi judges, most notoriously the screaming, aggressive Roland Freisler. Trials were held in secret, there was no right to appeal, and the number of death penalties skyrocketed.

3. The Early Concentration Camps The ultimate weapon of the police state was the concentration camp. The first camp, **Dachau**, was opened in 1933. In this early period (1933–39), these were primarily 'political' prisons, not the extermination camps they would later become. Inmates were mostly communists, trade unionists, outspoken journalists, and political rivals. They were used as forced labour, subjected to brutal beatings by SS guards, and deliberately kept in terrible conditions to serve as a terrifying warning to the rest of the population.

4. Controlling the Churches: The Catholic Concordat Religion was a massive threat to Hitler. Christianity preached peace, forgiveness, and loyalty to God over any earthly leader. In 1933, one-third of Germans were Catholic, and two-thirds were Protestant. Initially, Hitler tried to compromise with the Catholic Church. In **July 1933**, he signed the **Concordat** with the Pope. The Pope agreed that Catholic priests would stay out of German politics, and in return, Hitler promised not to interfere with Catholic schools or youth groups. However, Hitler quickly broke this treaty. By 1935, he had set up a dedicated **Ministry of Church Affairs** under Hanns Kerrl to systematically weaken religious power. In 1936, the state aggressively campaigned to remove crucifixes from Catholic classrooms, Catholic schools were forcibly closed, and the Catholic Youth League was banned. In 1937, a furious Pope Pius XI issued a scorching public letter called ***Mit brennender Sorge*** '(With Burning Concern)'. It was secretly smuggled into Germany and read out in every Catholic church, openly condemning Hitler's broken promises and his dangerous "myth of race and blood."

5. Controlling the Churches: The Protestants The Protestant churches were heavily divided. Hitler united the pro-Nazi Protestants into a single **Reich Church**, led by Ludwig Müller (the 'Reich Bishop'). Its members called themselves 'German Christians'. They wore Nazi uniforms, hung swastikas inside their churches, and demanded that the Old Testament of the Bible be banned because of its Jewish origins. In disgust, a brave First World War U-boat commander turned pastor named Martin Niemöller set up the **Pastors' Emergency League (PEL)**, which evolved into the rival **Confessional Church** in 1934. Over 6,000 Protestant pastors joined Niemöller, alongside theologians like Dietrich Bonhoeffer (who secretly trained

illegal pastors), in preaching against Nazi interference in religion. The Nazis responded with brutal force: Niemöller was arrested in 1937 and eventually sent to Sachsenhausen concentration camp, and hundreds of his pastors were imprisoned.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Why was the Gestapo so terrifying despite being relatively small?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete these sentences based on the lesson narrative: 1) Hitler signed the Concordat with the Catholic Church in 1933 BUT... 2) Hitler attempted to create a unified 'Reich Church' BECAUSE... 3) The Gestapo arrested many priests and pastors SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Write a short paragraph (5-7 sentences) explaining how the Nazi regime attempted to control and suppress religious institutions between 1933 and 1939. You must accurately use ALL of the following keywords: SS, SD, Gestapo, Schutzhaft, The Concordat (1933), Reich Church, Confessional Church.

Causal Linkage

Q4. Explain the chain of events that led to the formation of the Confessional Church and the subsequent Nazi response. Your explanation should clearly link each cause to its effect.

Counter-Factual History

Q5. Imagine the Nazi regime, from 1933, had chosen a policy of *immediate and complete suppression* of all religious institutions (Catholic and Protestant), rather than the historical path of initial conciliation (Concordat) and gradual subversion. Analyze the potential short-term and long-term consequences of this alternative policy for the Nazi regime's power, international standing, and public support within Germany, compared to the actual historical path.

L3: Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise knowledge of the methods Goebbels used to censor the press, literature, and radio.
- [ ] Analyse how the Nazis utilised mass rallies, the 1936 Berlin Olympics, and cheap technology (like the Volksempfänger) as tools of indoctrination.
- [ ] Evaluate the ways in which the Nazis crushed independent thought by controlling art, architecture, and music through the Reich Chamber of Culture.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Who was Paul von Hindenburg?

2. Who were the three chancellors before Hitler (1930-1932)?

3. Why did Hindenburg appoint Hitler as Chancellor in January 1933?

4. What percentage of the vote did the Nazis get in July 1932?

5. What was the Wall Street Crash?

6. How many Germans were unemployed by 1932?

7. How did Brüning try to fix the Depression?

8. Who was the first President of the Weimar Republic?

9. What was Article 48?

10. What was the Dawes Plan?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: *Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:*

Censorship | Propaganda | Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda | Volksempfänger (People's Receiver) | Reich Chamber of Culture | Entartete Kunst (Degenerate Art)

Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society



1. Goebbels and the Ministry of Propaganda In March 1933, Hitler appointed Joseph Goebbels as the Minister of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda. Goebbels was a mastermind of psychological manipulation. He understood that for propaganda to work, it had to be inescapable but often subtle. His goal was the 'Gleichschaltung' (coordination) of the German mind—ensuring that every time a citizen

opened a newspaper, turned on the radio, or went to the cinema, they absorbed the Nazi message.

> **Lived Experience: William L. Shirer (American CBS journalist, observing the 1934 Nuremberg Rally)**
> "About thirty thousand storm troopers were massed in squares. The morning light gleamed on their bayonets. When Hitler appeared, the roar of 'Heil!' was not polite applause; it was an ecstatic, religious frenzy."

2. Censorship: Crushing the Truth Goebbels systematically destroyed free speech in Germany to ensure no one could hear anti-Nazi viewpoints: ***The Press:*** *In October 1933, Goebbels passed the* **Schriftleitergesetz* (Editor's Law)**, making newspaper editors legally responsible for what was printed, effectively forcing them to censor themselves. Furthermore, the official Nazi publishing house, the **Eher Verlag**, systematically bought up independent newspapers. By 1939, the Nazis directly owned or controlled 82% of all newspapers in Germany. * **Literature:** In May 1933, Goebbels organised massive "Book Burnings" across Germany. Brainwashed university students threw over 20,000 books written by Jews, communists, and pacifists (like Albert Einstein and Karl Marx) into massive bonfires in Berlin.

3. Propaganda: Mass Rallies and the Radio Having silenced the opposition, Goebbels flooded Germany with Nazi ideology: ***The Radio:*** *Goebbels realised that hearing Hitler's charismatic voice was the most effective way to brainwash the public. He subsidised the mass production of the* **Volksempfänger*** (People's Receiver). These radios were deliberately designed with a short range so they could not pick up foreign stations like the BBC. By 1939, over 70% of German homes owned one. Crucially, listening was enforced: loudspeakers were erected in streets and factories, and sirens would sound to halt all work when Hitler made a major speech. * **Mass Rallies:** Every September, the Nazis held a massive rally in Nuremberg. These were carefully choreographed theatrical spectacles. Albert Speer, Hitler's favourite architect, designed the 'Cathedral of Light' using 130 anti-aircraft searchlights pointing into the night sky, creating a semi-religious, overwhelming atmosphere of power and unity. * **Film:** Cinemas were immensely popular. Goebbels commissioned director Leni Riefenstahl to make 'Triumph of the Will' (documenting the 1934 Nuremberg Rally), which is still studied today as a masterpiece of propaganda. However, 80% of Nazi films were actually comedies or dramas that just had subtle anti-Semitic or pro-Aryan messages woven into the plot.

4. The 1936 Berlin Olympics The 1936 Olympic Games provided Hitler with the ultimate global stage to showcase the "superiority" of the Aryan race and the efficiency of the Nazi state. * **The Deception:** Goebbels carefully paused the regime's brutality. Violent anti-Semitic newspapers like 'Der Stürmer' were temporarily removed from newsstands, and "Jews Not Wanted" signs were taken down. Foreign visitors left genuinely impressed by the clean, prosperous, and highly organised "New Germany". * **The International Failure vs. Domestic Success:** Hitler's primary goal was to prove Aryan racial supremacy. Internationally, this was undermined by the African-American athlete Jesse Owens, who won four gold medals. However, for the domestic German audience, the propaganda was a massive triumph: Germany dominated the overall medal table, winning 33 gold medals (far ahead of America's 24), which Goebbels used as 'proof' of Aryan superiority.

5. Controlling Culture and the Arts Hitler fancied himself an artist, and he believed that culture should reflect the heroic, traditional values of the German race. In September 1933, the **Reich Chamber of Culture** was set up. If you wanted to publish a book, sell a painting, or play in an orchestra, you 'had' to be a member. Jews and political opponents were banned. ***Art:*** *Modern, abstract art was despised by Hitler and banned as* **Entartete Kunst*** (Degenerate Art). In 1937, the Nazis held a massive 'Degenerate Art Exhibition' in Munich, where banned paintings were hung crookedly and surrounded by insulting graffiti to encourage the public to mock them. Instead, the Nazis promoted heroic, realistic paintings of muscular Aryan soldiers and fertile peasant women. * **Architecture:** Hitler favoured monumental, neoclassical architecture (huge stone buildings with classical pillars). Albert Speer designed buildings that were deliberately massive to make the individual feel small and the State feel eternal. * **Music:** Jewish composers (like Mendelssohn) were completely banned. American Jazz was outlawed because it was seen as "black music". Instead, Germans were encouraged to listen to traditional German composers like **Richard Wagner** and Beethoven.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Was Goebbels' propaganda or Himmler's terror more effective in controlling Germany?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete these sentences based on the lesson's narrative:
1) The Nazi regime established the Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda in March 1933, BUT...
2) Joseph Goebbels was appointed head of this Ministry BECAUSE...
3) The Nazis immediately began to control all forms of media, SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Using at least three of the keywords (Censorship, Propaganda, Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda, Volksempfänger, Reich Chamber of Culture, Entartete Kunst), write a short paragraph explaining how the Nazis controlled and influenced attitudes in Germany.

Causal Linkage

Q4. Explain how the Nazi regime's control over culture and media, through institutions like the Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda and the Reich Chamber of Culture, contributed to the consolidation of their power and the stability of the regime by 1939.

Q5. The 'What If' Challenge (Counter-Factual History): What if the Nazi regime had *failed* to establish effective control over radio and film in the early years (1933-1935)? How might this have significantly altered the trajectory of Nazi Germany's consolidation of power and public support by 1939?

L4: Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise knowledge of the different youth opposition groups, distinguishing between the working-class Edelweiss Pirates and the middle-class Swing Youth.
- [ ] Analyse the methods used by underground political networks, industrial workers, and lone-wolf attackers to resist the Nazi state.
- [ ] Evaluate the reasons why the vast majority of the German population conformed to Nazi rule rather than actively opposing it.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What happened to the Reichstag building in February 1933?

2. What was the Decree for the Protection of the People and State?

3. What was the Enabling Act (March 1933)?

4. What did Hitler do to trade unions in May 1933?

5. What was the Night of the Long Knives (June 1934)?

6. What title did Hitler take upon Hindenburg's death in 1934?

7. Who appointed Hitler as Chancellor?

8. Who convinced Hindenburg to appoint Hitler?

9. What was the SA?

10. What was the 25-Point Programme?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: *Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:*

Conformity | Passive Resistance | Active Resistance | Sopade Reports | Edelweiss Pirates | Swing Youth

> *"Between 1933 and 1939, youth groups like the Edelweiss Pirates and Swing Youth showed absolute Conformity to the Nazi police state by enthusiastically marching alongside the Gestapo."*

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:



1. The Illusion of Total Support: Why did most people conform? Looking back, it is easy to ask why millions of Germans didn't rise up against Hitler. The reality is that active opposition was incredibly dangerous. Most Germans conformed for two main reasons: * **Genuine Support:** By 1939, Hitler was genuinely popular with many Germans. He had smashed the hated Treaty of Versailles, rebuilt the army, and seemingly created an 'economic miracle' by drastically reducing unemployment. Many were willing to turn a blind eye to the brutality of the police state because they felt the Nazis were restoring national pride. * **Fear and the Scale of Repression:** The Gestapo and the block wardens terrified people into submission. Between 1933 and 1939, approximately **1.3 million Germans** were sent to concentration camps for political offenses, and another 300,000 fled the country entirely.

> **Lived Experience: Hans Scholl (Leader of the White Rose student resistance, Munich University 1942)**
> "Our present state is the dictatorship of evil. We must offer passive resistance wherever we can, before the last young German is sacrificed to the senseless bloodlust of the regime."

2. Underground Political and Worker Resistance When Hitler banned all rival political parties in 1933, opposition was forced underground. * **The SPD and the 'Sopade':** The Social Democratic Party leadership fled into exile. From abroad, they relied on a secret network of informants inside Germany to write the **Sopade reports**. These intelligence reports detailed the true mood of the working classes, proving that not everyone was completely brainwashed by Goebbels' propaganda. * **The Communists (KPD) and Workers:** The KPD continued to secretly print anti-Nazi leaflets. Furthermore, because Trade Unions were banned, industrial workers resisted in more subtle ways. They engaged in **passive resistance** and **sabotage**: deliberately working slowly ('slow-working'), calling in sick (absenteeism), or secretly damaging factory machinery to disrupt the Nazi economy. In 1936, there were even lightning strikes over high food prices.

Advanced Analysis: Lone-Wolf, Army, and Religious Resistance Not all resistance came from underground groups; some of the most dangerous opposition came from individuals and elites: * **The Lone Wolf:** In November 1939, a communist-sympathising carpenter named Georg Elser planted a sophisticated time bomb inside a Munich Beer Hall where Hitler was speaking. It detonated flawlessly, killing eight people, but Hitler had unexpectedly left the building just 13 minutes earlier. Elser was caught and executed in Dachau. * **Elite Army Discontent:** Not all generals supported Hitler. In 1938, General Ludwig Beck, the Chief of Staff of the German Army, actively plotted to overthrow Hitler and resigned his post in protest against Hitler's aggressive foreign policy, which he feared would cause another world war. * **The Protestant Church and the Confessional Church:** When the regime forced Protestant churches into the state-controlled Reich Church under Nazi bishop Ludwig Müller, dissenting pastors resisted. In 1933, Pastor **Martin Niemöller** and **Dietrich Bonhoeffer** established the **Pastors' Emergency League (PEL)**, which grew to over 6,000 pastors. In 1934, they founded the **Confessional Church**, openly rejecting Nazi control and the 'Aryan Paragraph' in churches. In response, the Gestapo arrested over 800 pastors. Niemöller himself was arrested in 1937 and imprisoned in Sachsenhausen and Dachau concentration camps until 1945. * **The Catholic Church and 'Mit brennender Sorge' (1937):** Hitler signed the **Concordat** with the Vatican in July 1933, promising to protect Catholic schools and youth groups if the Church stayed out of politics. However, the Nazis rapidly broke the treaty—harassing priests, shutting Catholic schools, and dissolving Catholic youth leagues. In March 1937, **Pope Pius XI** issued the famous papal encyclical **'Mit brennender Sorge'** ('With Burning Anxiety'). Smuggled into Germany on bicycles and read aloud from every Catholic pulpit on Palm Sunday, it openly condemned Nazi racism, state paganism, and the idolatry of Hitler. The regime retaliated with brutal show trials of priests on false charges of currency smuggling and sexual immorality. * **Religious Martyrs:** Linking back to the church opposition, Pastor Paul Schneider actively smuggled anti-Nazi letters out of his prison cell and refused to salute the swastika. Known as the "Preacher of Buchenwald," he was tortured and murdered by the SS in 1939.

3. Youth Opposition: The Edelweiss Pirates The Hitler Youth became compulsory in 1936. While many enjoyed it initially, as it became increasingly strict, militaristic, and focused on endless drilling, a counter-culture emerged. The **Edelweiss Pirates** emerged in the late 1930s (made up of local groups like the 'Navajos' in Cologne, or the 'Roving Dudes' in Essen). They were primarily **working-class** teenagers. They rebelled by: * Wearing their hair long and dressing in American-style checked shirts and white

socks. * Going on weekend hikes in the countryside to escape the suffocating control of the Nazi block wardens. * Singing banned songs (often changing the lyrics of Hitler Youth songs to mock the regime). * Taunting, ambushing, and physically beating up Hitler Youth patrols.

4. Youth Opposition: The Swing Youth While the Pirates were working-class, the **Swing Youth** were largely **middle and upper-class** teenagers in big cities like Berlin and Hamburg. They had the wealth to own record players and rebelled culturally rather than violently. * They illegally listened to banned American Jazz and Swing music (such as Glenn Miller), which the Nazis despised as "black" and "Jewish" music. * They dressed in sharp 'English' styles—boys carried umbrellas and wore tailored suits, while girls wore makeup (which the Nazis banned, as they wanted women to have a natural, 'peasant' look). * They organised illegal underground dances, attended by thousands, where they jitterbugged and smoked.

5. The Nazi Reaction to Youth Opposition Before the outbreak of war in 1939, the Nazi response to these youth groups was relatively lenient. The Gestapo would occasionally break up Swing Youth dances, confiscate record players, or arrest Edelweiss Pirates, shave their heads, and give them a severe beating before releasing them. The Nazis did not want to send thousands of young, healthy Aryans to concentration camps. '(Note: This would change drastically during WWII, when youth opposition became more political and the Nazi punishments became lethal).'

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Why was there so little resistance to the Nazi regime?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson narrative:
1) Early opposition groups like the SPD and KPD were quickly suppressed BUT...
2) The Confessional Church and Catholic Church resisted the Nazis BECAUSE...
3) Most Germans conformed to Nazi rule SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Write a short paragraph (approximately 100 words) explaining the different forms of opposition to the Nazi regime between 1933-1939, using at least five of the following keywords correctly: Conformity, Passive Resistance, Active Resistance, Sopade Reports, Sabotage, Edelweiss Pirates, Swing Youth.

Causal Linkage

Q4. Explain how a combination of Nazi policies and the nature of opposition led to widespread conformity rather than successful resistance in Germany between 1933 and 1939.

Counter-Factual History

Q5. Imagine a scenario where the SPD and KPD had managed to form a unified, underground resistance movement immediately after 1933, receiving significant support from the Confessional Church and trade unions. How might this have altered the nature and effectiveness of opposition to the Nazi regime by 1939, and what challenges would such a movement still have faced?